

Evolution of Values: A Pilot Study in a School in Bangalore

(Annexure: Stories and Questions)

Aim: To identify the patterns of evolution of values in 6-15 year old students and draw comparisons among the general category students and St/OBC category.

Objectives

1. Identify the conceptual understanding of values across the ages.
2. Identify the ways children are rewarded or awarded with respect to values.
3. Identify onset and nature of caste and gender discrimination.
4. To study differences for the above by gender.
5. To study differences for the above by caste.

Is our education system investing enough resources on character building of our children? Much time and effort is spent in mastering languages in schools; even larger amount of resources are spent on demanding subjects of mathematics and sciences as well. A belief that such knowledge would lead to decent livelihood do justify emphasising these critical subjects; but how critical is the value system of an individual? Are we investing in producing professionals who are driven by constructive values or are we just producing educated individuals who have 'distorted' values? For example, a doctor who is driven by a sole purpose of making profit and not driven by values (such as empathy and integrity) would certainly be harmful to his patients. The same could apply to scores of other professions. In the present day, given that most households have limitations in terms of encouraging inquisitiveness and creativity, leaving the complex matter of value education to parents and society is not only ineffective but also risky. If children are the building blocks of any society, character is the foundation of human beings. Character evolves from early years in childhood and its building requires independence of the mind coupled with guidance (not orders!) from adults. Some aspects of character that are valued for harmonious co-existence among human beings are integrity, courage, empathy, justice, kindness, conscientiousness, solution orientation and so on.

Acquisition of the above values, especially empathy and justice, not only requires clarity of thoughts for their in-depth comprehension but also requires guided effort, skilful retrospection and meaningful discussions. A very prominent outcome of not taking this approach towards value education may be seen in our-day-to day interaction with well-qualified Engineers, Managers, Doctors, and other well educated professionals who find the task of empathising with others immensely challenging; thereby jeopardising their own levels of satisfaction and productivity. In addition, inability to take a morally appropriate

decision has the potential to lead people into confusion, ignorance, denial and irresponsible behaviour. If we wish our country to really develop, we need to act towards changing the value system through effective education; by making humane, happy professionals rather than confused or un-empathetic ones.

Some relevant thoughts on the subject are as follows:

"The prosperity of a country depends not on the abundance of its revenues, not on the strength of its fortifications, nor on the beauty of its public buildings; but on its cultivated citizens, in its men of education, enlightenment and character." -----Martin Luther King

"[I]f things go wrong under the Constitution the reason will not be that we had a bad Constitution. What we will have to say is that Man is vile!"-----B.R. Ambedkar

"...required beliefs cannot be hammered in; the needed attributes cannot be plastered on." -----John Dewey

"Do unto others as you would have them do unto you" or "do not do unto others as you would not have them do unto you".-----Golden Law or Ethic of Reciprocity

As a first step towards designing an 'intervention', this pilot study was an attempt to uncover the nuances around some select values in children who were exposed to 'Value Education' in school.

Background

Various studies have been carried out on evolution of moral values among children, The Moral Judgement of the Child based on Jean Piaget's research published in 1932 was first of its kind. He studied the moral development of small children through adolescence in the areas of lying, stealing, justice, etc. and established a sequence of stages that children followed as they evolved in moral reasoning and actions. Even though it was found to be lacking in several areas, this study went on to become the foundation for several other studies on the same subject. For example, Kohlberg carried out a modified version of Piaget's moral development research and studied the phenomena in some 27 countries, including India, Kenya, Turkey etc. (Colby and Kohlberg, 1987) and established six stages that children follow as they evolve in their moral reasoning. After several validation and reliability tests by other psychologists, Kohlberg's stages were found to be more robust and universally applicable.

Further to this, several other psychologists such as Erikson, Freud, Vygotsky, Eisenberg, Hoffman and Bandura have proposed many theories in the same area and highlighted the importance of culture, society, parenting styles, gender etc. towards shaping the moral character of a child. For example, Hoffman found that "the internalisation of an external norm occurs when a person feels an obligation to act in accord with the norm even

in absence of concern about being caught and punished if they do otherwise" (Hoffman, 1991). According to Hoffman, certain parenting styles are negatively associated with empathy development. Discipline that focusses on how the action has affected another individual leads to stronger internalisation of empathy; punishment does not. His study on empathy is well supported and established that the ability to adopt another's perspective marks the onset of pro-social behaviour and leads to more compassion in people. In addition to the studies done in the past, there are many social scientists, neurologists and psychologists already working on this issue. Some neuroscientists are already working on identifying neurological factors responsible for ethical behaviour so as to eventually (ethics permitting) make humans ethical (audio: <http://www.bbc.co.uk/radio/player/p00rdps3>).

Inspired by similar studies, the researcher developed thematic short stories on moral dilemma suitable for the Indian social fabric incorporating gender and caste discrimination.

Data was collected from 37 school going boys and girls aged between 6 and 15 years.

The entire sample is divided into 3 parts based on ages, viz. 6-8 (Group 1); 9-12 (Group 2); and 13-15 years (Group 3). Children were reserved category were also sampled.

Findings of the Pilot Study

Since this study was strictly qualitative in nature, it would not be possible to mark evolution quantitatively for most part at this stage. This is an area to work on, if this study gets scaled up. However, based on the above analysis, some patterns can be highlighted. This study involved values such as *hard-work*, *cheating*, *empathy*, *greed*, gender discrimination, stealing, action-orientation, caste discrimination. The results not only show findings around these areas but also reveal some other essential *underlying* factors. All the relevant factors are listed below:

1. **Comprehension** was poor for 1st Group but it improved consistently. However, the **ability to imagine and reason** was weak for most children; these improved drastically from 1st to 2nd group and only slightly for the 3rd group. There were still a large number of children in the 2nd group who needed constant intervention to facilitate comprehension.
2. In this **English medium** School, majority children were poor in basic English vocabulary and **grammar**.
3. Related to the above is the ability to express emotions or situations using variety of words. This too was very poor.
4. Ability to **empathise** only got better but the degree of improvement was more from 1st to 2nd than from 2nd to 3rd group. In the 3rd group, even though more children were able to perceive '*trust*', '*apathy*' and '*insult*' factors, many were unable to empathise with poverty

and stealing caused by hunger. Between the 2nd and 3rd group, the latter exhibited deeper *empathy*. Even upto the 3rd stage, children assumed adults to be always truthful, implying lack of questioning attitude.

5. A clear act of ***cheating*** was not perceived as *cheating* by many. Perception of *cheating* improved only from group 1st to 2nd and remained constant for the 3rd group. ***Hard-work*** and ***fairness*** was consistently emphasised by all in all ages. Although, many children up to the 2nd group stated **punishment or reward** as a reason to do their work unlike the older ones who stated **learning and success** as the motivation behind working hard. Many older children were able to realise drawbacks of being 'lazy'.
6. With age, choice of **punishment** shifted to non-corporal. It may not be conclusive at this stage but most children who chose non-corporal punishment were also better in reasoning and comprehension abilities. As a side observation, it was found that the school relied heavily on corporal punishment of the children, especially the younger ones.
7. **Action orientation** also improved with age. This aspect is best left to be tested in a more realistic setting than under such hypothetical story telling session where it was much easier to suggest action for another unrelated character.
8. There was no visible **gender discrimination** or related thought that was observed **within the school premises**.
9. The meaning and concept of **caste** was missing in most children as only the 3rd group claimed to know its meaning. Even here, most mixed up caste with religion and their sub-castes. Even though children did not perceive any difference with respect to caste, it was observed that in the second group, children from reserved category were weaker in communication, comprehension and reasoning.
10. Out of all children, only 1/3rd of children (falling into the 3rd group) knew the meaning of ***greed*** and considered it to be unacceptable.
11. In the 2nd group, girls out-performed boys in areas of *empathy*, reasoning and communication.

Conclusion

The school chosen was an English medium private school. To the researchers' observation, the following relevant areas need attention: poor expression in English, weak working memory, poor comprehension, poor simple mental math, liberal use of corporal punishment to discipline children, lack of creative thinking and fear. Piaget's cognitive development theories indicate that the process of learning involves 'disequilibrium', and

Kohlberg's studies have confirmed that the 'disequilibrium'¹ is needed for development of values too (2009, McLeod). It is obvious that there are two prerequisites to learning in this way: inquisitiveness and reasoning abilities; absence of either will affect the course of learning. In this study, most children were found to be weak in both. In addition, surprisingly, many children even in the 2nd group were unable to solve the simple word problem in the last story. These points are being brought up because they could correlate with the quality of children's learning. This raises questions about utilising their true potential as well as the quality of the lessons learnt. The observations and findings also raise a question: are children of this school spending their early years in fear of punishment? With the practice of corporal punishment in primary wing, assuming that punishment has affected their learning may not be so far from reality.

The school chosen for the study imparts value education in a classroom setting, like most other subjects. The possibility to engage in meaningful discussion over values and debate was found to be missing, as per few students. This also corroborates with the limited ability of most children to reason and imagine in most children. Ability to imagine underlies development of *empathy*, which further underlies responsible actions. If children are not taught to empathise in school, there is no guarantee if they would learn it elsewhere. Parenting styles have been associated with development of *empathy* by Psychologists such as Hoffman (McLeod) but leaving the task of value education to parents, who may or may not adopt the 'best practices', may adversely affect the collective values we share as a society. Lack of complete *empathy*, as found in this study, would make children poor perceivers and judges of acts such as *cheating*, *trust* and their effects. Further, it was surprising to find only few children who knew the concept of *greed* even in higher age group. *Greed* or lack of contentment is at the core of corruption in our society. When exactly will these children learn about this dreadful vice?

At this juncture, it may be worthwhile to raise questions on time spent and method adopted for inculcating values: one period each week in a classroom setting. The kind of individuals we see in the real world is an outcome of the efforts we put in educating our children. The format and the dissemination could be questionable too! We will not know unless we attempt to find out. Children learn a lot from general practices around them and when practice contradicts classroom lessons, confusion is bound to set in and the decision is then left to the discretion of that confused little mind. This aspect of curriculum design and dissemination, however important, was not within the realms of the current study.

This study has highlighted some important concerns for the moral development of the children in the areas of reasoning, creative thinking, imagination, expression, missing

¹ Disequilibrium is a state of mind that results from encountering new information (that does not 'fit-in' with the rest of knowledge base) and causing the brain to ponder as a result of noticing the new thing and then either making a place for it in the mind.

concepts of caste and *greed*. It must be noted that this school might be an above average school in terms of quality of education and facilities as well as gender equality, caste equality and concept of fairness. Therefore, even if statistically not representative, the proportion of 'weak performers' in this study was far from massive. At the same time, the proportion was not too small to ignore either.

Issues and Concerns for Future Research

1. Firstly, the researcher set out to explore the thoughts with respect to values but ended up with several other related aspects that may have an effect on acquiring the stated values. Most children were unable to express their thoughts or reasons behind their decisions. This made it hard to find out what their actual thoughts were. Perhaps, in future, connections could be explored between comprehension, family background, parenting styles, communication/expression skill, reasoning abilities, and the various value parameters.
2. Based on the above findings, value parameters must be defined clearly for measurement. For example, due to lack of proper definition, it was challenging to determine the degree of empathy exhibited by a child. I have used terms such as 'deep empathy' or 'little empathy' based on a child's ability to relate with the number of characters and their emotions. But these terminologies need refining for future.
3. It is worth probing if the same children respond the same way to the similar questions if asked later on? Reason being, sometimes post-interview reflections may lead to change in reasoning...after all this was moral dilemma we were testing them on. Dilemmas can precipitate varied responses depending upon the state of mind.
4. The same questionnaire could be used to test if children in small groups respond differently. If questioned in a small group of 3-4 children, each child thinks more competitively and tries to be more creative in reasoning. The consciousness from being the only one interviewed is removed in such a setting. However, the down side of this could be that one may influence the answer of another. It would be hard to tell why respondent said what he/she said unless it was original / unique.
5. The questions were based on hypothetical stories and their responses, as has been criticised earlier, may not be relevant in real life situations. To tackle this, perhaps games or simulations could be designed to make the test more realistic.
6. The questionnaire was rather lengthy but suitable for an in-depth qualitative research. In case of a quantitative study on this subject, the present method may need to be modified else it would be too cost intensive. It not only consumed an

average of 1 hour per child but also needed skill and patience in telling the stories, ensuring that the stories were understood, probing for in-depth understanding and recording responses.

7. Finally, to get a wider and deeper picture on 'values', studies could be designed on similar lines to obtain data from adults, parents, teachers, youth etc.

Annexure 1: Stories and Questions

Theme: Integrity (values studied were 'hard-work', 'cheating', 'trust')

Integrity - Neutral

Ashok is very good in studies and is popular too. All teachers and students adore him. Since he is the top scorer of the class, his class teacher asks him to check answer sheets of some students quite often. Ashok himself works very hard to get good marks but he gives high marks to his lazy friends. The teacher *trusts* Ashok and since everyone likes him, nobody complains. Every time Ashok gets papers to evaluate, he tries to help his friends without telling anyone.

Questions: a) Is it alright to do what Ashok is doing? Why?; B) Should the teacher know about this?; C) Who should tell the teacher?; D) Should the students being helped by Ashok tell?; E) What should the teacher do upon finding out?; F) Should Ashok be punished? How?; G) Why is Ashok *cheating* the teacher? Where could he have learnt to cheat?

Integrity- Gender

Arun, Saurabh and Sarika were given a painting assignment. Saurabh and Sarika always work hard to make their paintings by themselves. But Arun does not like to paint, so, he is very worried about this homework. Arun asks his friend to make the painting for him and buys him ice-cream for this favour. Sarika finds out that Arun is *cheating*. When she tells Arun to do his own work else she would complain to his mother and the teacher, Arun threatens her of hurting her if she told anyone. Sarika is confused because Arun is much stronger than her.

Questions: A) What should Sarika do? Why?; B) If Sarika tells the teacher, what would the teacher do?; C) If she tells Arun's mother, what would Arun's mother do?; D) Why does he not do his own work?; E) Where did Arun learn to cheat and *lie*?; F) Should Arun be Punished? How?; G) If Arun is punished for his *cheating*, how would he feel?; H) If he is not punished, then how would he feel?; I) Why should he be told to do his own work?; J) Should boys be punished differently than girls when found to be *cheating*?

Integrity- Caste

Sunil is very good in acting and he loves to act on stage. When a school drama selection contest is announced, he works very hard for the selection. On the day of selection, many students participate and perform in front of each other and some teachers. Everyone loved Sunil's performance. However, the drama teacher selected Sudeep since she did not want a student from poor family to be in her drama. Sunil's poor father is a cleaner at the same school.

Questions: A) If you were watching the selection process, what would you feel?; B) Should someone do something about it? Who and what?; C) What should Sunil do and why?; D) Should someone be punished here? Who, how and by whom?; E) Would you punish someone? Who?; F) Should caste or category of a child affect his or her selection in drama? What could be the caste of Sunil?; F) How would Sunil and his interest in acting be affected if not selected?; G) Whose fault is it that the teacher did not choose Sunil? How did the teacher get to be this way?; H) Does Sunil's father have the power to do something for his son? What and how?

THEME: Pro-Social Behaviour (Values studied: 'Empathy', 'lying', 'action orientation')

Pro-Social Behaviour- Neutral

Anshu saved money from his pocket money to buy his brother, Monu, a gift for his birthday. He wrapped up a very nice toy and presented to his brother during the birthday party in front of all his friends. Monu opened the gift and quickly kept it aside saying, "That is not what I wanted. There is nothing new about this toy ". Anshu was so badly hurt by Monu's reaction that he ran inside and cried throughout the party, while Monu continued playing with his friends.

Questions: A) Why did Anshu cry so much? ; B) Had Monu said to Anshu in private (not in front of friends), would Anshu have cried this much?; C) Should Monu do something? What?; D) Why was Monu so rude to Anshu?; E) Is it wrong to hurt other's feelings? Why? Why does Monu not know this?; F) Will Anshu and Monu still be friends?

Pro-Social Behaviour- Gender

There was only one swing at the park on which Raghav was swinging merrily. Aruna had been waiting for her turn for a long time but Raghav was enjoying swinging so much that he would not let go of the swing for Aruna. Aruna began crying and asked the teacher for help. The teacher was too busy with her work and she ignored Aruna's request. So Aruna went home in tears and Raghav continued swinging merrily.

Questions: A) Who is at fault? Why?; B) Should someone be punished? How and why?; C) Do girls and boys get equal chance to play or boys play more? Why?; D) If Sunita was swinging in place of Raghav and Raghav was waiting endlessly, would the teacher have helped him?

Pro-Social Behaviour- Caste

Varun and Anil go to the same class. Anil looks like a boy from very poor family as his shirt is not always clean and his shoe soles are worn out. Varun comes from a rich family but still they are good friends. One day, Anil could not bring lunch and was shy to ask Varun for his help. So, he stole food from another student's bag. Varun caught Anil stealing. He is confused whether to complain to the teacher or let Anil eat because he is poor and hungry.

Questions: A) Is Anil doing the right thing by stealing food? Why?; B) What should Varun do? If he should help, till when can he help Anil? ; C) When should he tell the teacher?; D) Can Varun's parents get involved in some way?; E) What would happen if he tells the teacher? How would Anil feel?; F) Is it never right to steal or one can steal under certain situations? What situations?; G) If Anil was not Varun's friend, should he have told the teacher immediately?

THEME: Greed

Greed- Neutral

Navin belongs to a rich family and his parents buy him whatever he asks for. Navin also gets money to go to school by bus but he chose to walk mostly so that he can save 20 Rs everyday and buy goodies for himself later. When his mother asks, he always says he went by bus. One day, his Aunt sees him walking to school and tells his mother. When confronted, he lies because otherwise his mother will stop giving him the money.

Questions: A) If Navin's parents give him everything he asks for, why does he *lie*?; B) What should the mother do? Should his mother believe Navin's aunt or Navin? Why?; C) Why is Navin *lying*?; D) Is Navin greedy? Is *greed* good?

Greed- Neutral

Shweta's mother gives her 100 chocolates to distribute in her class for her birthday. She gives only 20 to her close friends and keeps the rest for herself.

Questions: A) Is she greedy?; B) What should her mother do if she finds out? ; C) Can one be greedy sometimes? When?; D) When is *greed* good and when is it bad?; E) Why are some children greedy? Where do they learn?

Direct Questions

1. Who sits in the last row?
2. Who cleans the class? Who asks them to clean the class?
3. Where does everyone get water from? Are there different water outlets for different children?
4. Where do you drink water from?
5. Can you sit anywhere and with anyone?
6. Are there children from different castes in your class? What castes?
7. Is any caste bad? What do you feel for children from bad caste?
8. Is there any teacher who is partial towards students from good caste?
9. Where did you learn about good and bad castes?
10. Do you see a difference between poor and rich children? What?
11. Does someone ask you to NOT mingle with someone...who? Who asks you to?
12. How many schools have you changed so far? Why?
13. What do you like to do in school and what do you dislike doing here?
14. Does anything trouble or bother you in this school? What?
15. Do you ask questions in the class? If not, why?
16. Do you answer questions when you know the answer? If not, why?
17. What would you liked changed about your experience in school/s?